

Almonte and district

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County-wide break-ins doubled in 1985, OPP estimate

By Rosemary MacVicar, Gazette reporter

Perth OPP records show that over \$184,000 in property was stolen during 169 break-ins across the county in the detachment area last year, and although comparable 1984 statistics aren't available, a police spokesman estimates that break-ins and thefts have doubled in the area from 1984.

"I think what we're dealing with here is human greed," commented Const Neil Fennell, Perth detachment community services officer. "I think it's clear to the criminal that this is easy and the chances of getting caught are relatively slim."

He said property which is stolen during these incidents can be fenced quickly outside the immediate area.

Some municipalities including the townships of Ramsay and Beckwith are particularly attractive to criminals because of their proximity to Ottawa. While Beckwith was the location of more break-ins than any other of the 14 county municipalities policed by the Perth OPP, Ramsay ranked third.

A total of 25 break-ins occurred at permanent residences in Ramsay during the year, including 18 daylight break-ins.

There were 41 of these incidents in Beckwith during 1985, including 25 daylight occurrences.

Pakenham Township ranks fifth on this scale with 12 break-ins — including eight which happened during the day.

Const Fennell noted that these and other municipalities are close to the Ottawa area, enabling thieves to sell stolen property for cash, often before the break-in is reported to police.

The 1985 statistics, which exclude break-ins and thefts at cottages, seasonal homes and outside residences, emphasize the need for community-based crime prevention, said the community services officer.

"It makes a loud statement that something like Neighborhood Watch is quite necessary."

Const Fennell is organizing information meetings and approaching municipal councils about the program. Later he plans to travel door-to-door in the county to make residents aware of the program.

"Locally, he expects to address Pakenham Township council in late January. An information meeting is to be conducted in Ramsay, although the date hasn't been set yet."

Neighbors organize to observe each others property at times when crime is

most likely to happen and report suspicious activities and individuals in Neighborhood Watch.

The geography of the county, with residents living over a scattered area, especially in rural locations, presents a particular challenge to organizing Neighborhood Watch.

"It's not going to be easy. It's going to need a commitment," commented Const Fennell.

Ramsay

A review of the statistics at the Ramsay Township council meeting last week prompted councillor Don Duncan to suggest the time is ripe to press for additional police protection.

"If we are ever going to push for getting a detachment locally in North Lanark (County), we should be doing it in the next few years," he said.

Councillor Duncan said support exists for another detachment in Almonte and Pakenham Township. He suggested area residents form a committee and work a presentation to make to officials in Toronto.

A total of 94 of the 169 break-ins in OPP records were recorded as occurring in daylight, although Const Fennell noted more of them may have taken place in the day. He said the time of an occurrence can't be pinned down exactly when residents are away for several days.

Other municipalities ranked among the top five in the Perth OPP jurisdiction were Montague and Dalhousie and Lanark townships.

The 31 break-ins in Montague, including 18 daylight incidents, put the township in second place.

Dalhousie and Lanark Township tied for the fourth spot with 15 break-

ins taking place in each municipality during the last year.

The Perth OPP statistics were compiled for municipalities within the detachment jurisdiction. They don't include communities such as Almonte and Carleton Place where other police forces exist.

A minute portion of property stolen during these incidents is recovered. Const Fennell estimated that roughly five per cent of stolen property is recovered.

The sole bright spot was the drop in break-ins as 1985 drew to a close. The numbers decreased from 27 in September, to 21 in October, to 16 in November. Complete statistics weren't available for December, but as of Dec 15, eight break-ins had taken place in Perth detachment area.

Appleton mill ruins could be protected by historical designation

Ramsay Township council has taken the first step towards finding out if it's feasible to preserve or stabilize the historic Teskey mill ruins at Appleton.

Council initiated the process of having the mill, which Robert Teskey originally built in 1863, designated a heritage site.

This designation, if approved, "means that we're eligible for some funding, but more importantly in this case, that we will be able to have some control and get some funding in doing a feasibility study," commented councillor Don Duncan at the Dec 20 Ramsay council meeting.

Council took this action after reviewing a letter from Herb Pragnell

on behalf of the Mississippi Valley Textile Museum.

The letter was written, to confirm council's interest in the ruins which Mr Pragnell described as "famous and irreplaceable."

Heritage designation of the site, if and when this is obtained won't guarantee preservation of the ruins, but would enable a feasibility study to be conducted.

"We are interested in exploring the feasibility of stabilizing the ruins so they're not demolished... At least some attempt (can) be made to save them," commented Diane Duncan, museum coordinator.

She said the National Capital Commission has promised to assist with

such a feasibility study. A letter from the NCC states the organization "would be interested in the preservation of the ruins by providing some consultant expertise," said Mrs Duncan.

She noted the ruins role in local tourism. "They are one of the key things that draw tourists into the Appleton area," she commented.

Originally the ruins structure was a four-storey stone mill, when Robert Teskey built it. His son John Adam Teskey constructed an addition to it in 1880.

Thomas Boyd Caldwell, then Liberal MP for North Lanark, is recorded as owning the Teskey or Mississippi Woolen Mills for more than 30 years

beginning in 1900.

The mills were next to the property of Collier Woolen Mills Limited. The mills were destroyed during a devastating fire in 1950. The Collier family continues to own them.

Robert Teskey, the mill builder, was a member of the Teskey family which settled and developed the village of Appleton. The family emigrated to Ramsay Township during 1823 from southern Ireland.

The village was known as Teskeyville for a period preceding 1857.

Mr Duncan said mills such as the one located at Merrickville, have been stabilized by sealing them from further water damage.

The current landowner, Jim Collier, supports the idea of preserving the mills, noted councillor Duncan. Mr Collier couldn't be reached for comment by press time Monday.

Mr Duncan stressed that designation is necessary before any other action can occur. "Unless the township goes through the designation process we will not get a penny towards the feasibility study or anything," he commented. He stressed that council doesn't want to infringe on the landowner.

While council has started the designation process, the Local Architectural Conservation Advisory Committee will take the necessary steps before council decides about the heritage designation.

Mr Hallett said the authority has received questions connected to building such a station at the site, but he isn't aware of any concrete proposals. Again, Mr Collier couldn't be reached for comment.

"There may be an idea at this stage I don't think it's progressed very far," said Mr Hallett.

The Mississippi Valley Conservation Authority (MVCA) supports preservation of the heritage value of the site.

Del Hallett, MVCA general manager, said it would probably be possible to establish a hydro generating station at the ruins and preserve the heritage value.

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RC teachers with 12 years experience to earn over \$44,000 after contract accepted

By Rosemary MacVicar, Gazette reporter

The new Roman Catholic teachers' 4.5 per cent salary increase makes the annual salary for the highest paid Lanark, Leeds and Grenville County Catholic separate school board teacher \$44,305.

This salary is set for a qualified teacher with 12 years experience. The 4.5 per cent raise is part of the 1985-86 contract for approximately 200

teachers and principals employed at elementary and secondary schools in the tri-county board system.

A first-year teacher in the system who has graduated from teachers' college earns \$20,579 annually, with the increase. Some board teachers' salaries may be lower, depending on their qualifications.

"I think most teachers are fairly satisfied with the contract," commented Keith McPhee, chief negotiator for the teachers. "We are always look-

ing for as close to parity with the public board as possible."

He said while the separate school teachers haven't yet achieved this goal, they moved "much closer" to it with the new contract.

He described contract negotiations which concluded when both parties ratified the agreement in December, as "amicable."

Frank Musca, board director of education agreed. "It was a friendly settlement between the teachers and the

board," he commented.

Mr McPhee said that one change in the contract concerning teacher redundancy provides better "protection for the teachers."

The clause was improved, said Mr McPhee, so that when teachers are redundant, the decision about letting them go is "based now to a greater degree on seniority."

"Other changes affect the benefits package.

Rental insurance payments are now calculated on 1985 rate, rather than the 1983 rates used previously.

The life insurance coverage offered in the contract has increased from \$40,000 to \$54,000.

The board pays 80 per cent of OHIP and extended health care insurance premiums, 75 per cent of group life insurance premiums and 70 per cent of dental insurance premiums for the teachers and principals.

Board principals are paid according to the salary grid for other teachers. In addition to their salaries, principals receive a responsibility allowance. Mr Musca said the maximum responsibility allowance paid to a principal in the system is approximately \$8,500.

Board teachers and principals belong to the Ontario English Catholic Teachers' Association.

Their contract is retroactive to Sept 1, 1985 and expires Aug 31, 1986.

Financing PUC plan pondered

How the public utilities commission intends to pay for the ambitious Almonte Hydro Development Feasibility Study will depend on what Barber Hydraulics proposes in its final report, but one thing is certain — the town's ratepayers will be footing the bill.

Newly-elected PUC chairman Jack Virgin said the commissioners intend to "explore all areas" and aspects of carrying out the necessary works, but admitted "it would not be practical, at first glance" to try to have them completed in one or two years.

The costs outlined in the study range in estimates from over \$1.4 million to \$3 million. The PUC could debenture, borrow enough money to carry out any of those proposals, or include the items in its capital budget and spread the projects out over a long-term period.

The latter scheme would make "more economic sense," Mr Virgin said, because there is no guarantee the power house would produce any more energy in the short term to "make it feasible."

He said the PUC, once it has been determined how much is to be spent, would likely spread the works out over "five to 10 years" — likely closer to 10.

An "ongoing program" of maintenance and upgrading of the plant and head pond would allow the commission to gradually carry out the needed works as detailed in the study, he said.

"With a four per cent inflation rate now, there's no point in rushing in... I don't want to see my hydro bill jump 20 per cent overnight," he said.

The PUC's ability to fund the works still depends on the Barber Hydraulics/Pitts Construction to construct two new units, possibly "in the bay." The firm proposes a "three or four million dollar prestage, well, we just can't finance that type of project."

Under the long-term scheme, Mr Gallagher said, the PUC could



The Almonte power house and the other facilities around it could be the site of some major overhauls if the public utilities commission accepts some or all of the recommendations contained in a study proposing the upgrading of hydro electric services in the town.

reconstruct one of the two units "a year" and "do it ourselves" rather than hiring someone to carry it out.

Another possibility would be, he said, for Barber Hydraulics/Pitts Construction to construct two new units, possibly "in the bay." The town would buy the power from the firms and then, if the costs were not prohibitive, purchase the generators 20 years later at an agreed upon price.

The firms would reap tax benefits, said Mr Gallagher, and the town's ratepayers wouldn't be faced with a large prestage all at once.

Debenturing would require town approval, and so the PUC wants "to be sure of what they're getting into" before committing itself one way or the other.

The PUC is awaiting word from Barber Hydraulics for its recommendations (see related story).

Warrant issued for arrest of White Lake man

A warrant has been issued for the arrest of a 28-year-old RR 2 White Lake man charged with possessing a prohibited weapon and threatening the police.

The warrant was issued for Desmond Warren, 28, of RR 2, White Lake, after Mr Warren's cottage was searched by Perth and Renfrew OPP officers on Dec 30.

A 12-gauge sawed-off shotgun, three pills, white powder weighing approximately 35 grams and drug paraphernalia were seized during the Dec 30 search.

The seized drug paraphernalia included scales, vials and other utensils.

• Almonte man fined \$280

An Almonte area man, who pleaded guilty to eight counts of making false statements in order to receive Unemployment Insurance benefits, was fined a total of \$280 during an appearance in Carleton Place Provincial Court January 3.

The charge was laid against Allan Mitchell, 30, of RR 2 Almonte.

Investigation and Control Officer with Employment and Immigration Canada John Neufeld, who was in court, stated the accused had filled out reports from a period beginning February 24 to June. During that time, said Neufeld, Mitchell had earned \$6,005 working with Spratt's Sand and Gravel and therefore was not entitled to the sum of \$2,678 he received from Unemployment Insurance.

Mitchell's lawyer, Evelyn Wheeler, said her client had accumulated a large bank debt following a separation and because of that, "had succumbed to keeping the cheques." She pointed out that although not presently employed, he is not receiving any money from Unemployment Insurance although he is eligible. Instead, she stated, the money he has already received is being used to pay the \$2,678 debt.

Wheeler asked the court to take into consideration Mitchell's desperate

Police Beat

financial situation at the time of the offence. She said "he was merely using the money to support himself and two children aged two and six years of age."

"He left financially squeezed," said Wheeler, "and did not know what to do."

Neufeld stated he would normally ask for a period of incarceration in regards to the charges. "However," he told the court, "while a serious crime has been committed, I see no point in having a large fine due to the circumstances."

Provincial Judge David Dempsey, before handing down sentence, said he would take into account the severe financial strain of the accused as well as the nature of the offence. He levied a fine of \$335 for each of the eight offences with three months to pay, with an alternative of 14 days in jail.

• Damage done to vehicles

There was nearly \$2,000 damage to two vehicles which collided at the intersection of Martin and Augusta streets because of snow and ice Jan 3.

Linda Louise Murray, 37, of 5 Gale Street, was driving west on Augusta when she was unable to stop at the Martin Street intersection. Snow and ice prevented her from stopping the vehicle, report Almonte OPP.

She drove through the intersection, striking a 1979 GMC driven by Daniel J. Illingworth, 20, of 149 Water Street at 5:25 p.m. Mr Illingworth had been driving the vehicle north on Martin.

There was approximately \$1,800 damage to the left side door, fender and hood of the Pontiac and \$150 damage to the right front corner,

bumper and grill of the GMC.

No one was injured and no charges were laid in connection with the accident.

• Car strikes guideway

No one was injured and no charges were laid as a result of a single-vehicle accident on Lanark County Road 20 in Pakenham Township Dec 30.

Peterborough resident Todd Morin, 21, was negotiating a right-hand curve on the county road when the 1983 Dodge he was driving crossed the road and struck a guideway at 6:15 p.m.

There was approximately \$2,000 damage to the left rear of the Dodge during the accident which occurred two kilometres east on the Renfrew County line.

Ottawa OPP officers investigated the accident.

• Ski theft season again

Police are warning skiers to protect their equipment against theft as they hit the slopes and trails this season.

The Perth OPP detachment has received two recent reports of the local ski thefts.

An Almonte resident's equipment was stolen at the Mount Pakenham ski area when it was left outdoors unattended.

The stolen property belonging to David McNeely, of 83 Elgin Street consisted of white Fischer Grand Prix skis, size 180, and bindings in a red and blue Dynastar ski bag.

The theft took place at approximately 11 p.m. June 4.

The detachment has received at least one other report of stolen ski equipment recently.

Const Neil Fennell, Perth OPP community services officer, said he plans to visit the ski area to mark equipment for easy identification later in the winter.

Councillor not named to fire committee

An item contained in the Dec 10 'Council Briefs' of Almonte town council identified councillor Dorothy Finner as a member of the Almonte-Ramsay fire protection

committee.

In fact, Mrs Finner was not named to this committee. She will, as the story continues, be a member of the Almonte-Ramsay fire protection

board and the Almonte Library Board.

The Gazette apologizes for any confusion the item may have caused.